

Vowel sounds

THE ENGLISH ALPHABET CONTAINS FIVE VOWELS: *A, E, I, O, AND U*.

Each vowel has a short or long phoneme, or sound. Each sound made by a vowel can be written down as a grapheme—one or more letters that represent a sound.

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Short vowel sounds

A vowel can sound short, or abrupt. For example, the word *rat* has a short “a” sound and the grapheme that represents this sound is *a*. A more complex word, such as *tread*, has a short “e” sound and the grapheme is *ea*. The letter *y* sometimes takes the place of a vowel. For example, the word *gym* has a short “i” sound but the grapheme is *y*.

The **Taa language**, spoken mainly in Botswana, has **112 different sounds**.

a

▷ Short “a”

This sound is represented only by the grapheme *a*.

cat

e

▷ Short “e”

This sound is represented by the graphemes *a*, *ai*, *e*, *ea*, *eo*, and *ie*.

many

said

reptile

head

leopard

friend

i

▷ Short “i”

This sound is represented by the graphemes *e*, *i*, *o*, *u*, and *y*.

pretty

insect

women

busy

rhythm

o

▷ Short “o”

This sound is represented by the graphemes *a* and *o*.

salt

octopus

u

▷ Short “u”

This sound is represented by the graphemes *o*, *ou*, and *u*.

dove

young

buffalo